

cores was accurate data of the Eemian period that we scientists hope to get from the NEEM project," says Valerie Masson-Delmotte, a French team member whose enthusiasm is infectious. It may prove a useful analogue to the future climate. Or then it may not. But as Rosing points out, "Edison didn't invent the light bulb as a result of a project to develop on the candle."

To get that data is a logistical nightmare for the team. For the NEEM project site is literally in the middle of nowhere and is difficult to reach by land. It was chosen because radar and satellite studies showed that the site was the best place to harvest Eemian ice cores. So the US, whose scientists are also part of the project, agreed to provide LC-130 aeroplanes from the US Air Force, to provide the main transport for both goods and manpower. It can land both on wheels and skis

and has rockets fitted on its sides to give it the extra boost for take-off. Assuming the role of chief logistician is Jorgen Peder Steffensen, whose wife Dorthe heads the project. Between them they co-ordinate the back-breaking task of setting up the camp and moving equipment across the ice.

The bearded Steffensen, who is a curator at the Niels Bohr Institute for Astronomy in Copenhagen, didn't know that NEEM was the name for a medicinal plant till one of the scientists presented him with an Indian toothpaste bearing that name. The staging ground for the camp is the Greenland town of Kangerlussuaq, four-and-a-half hours by air from Copenhagen. At Kangerlussuaq, Steffensen takes us for a ride in what he calls his "limo" but really a battered SUV with a cargo trailer. He manages to squeeze eight of

us into the vehicle and takes to the wheel with the flair of a Delhi taxi driver.

As we bounce across the mud road to reach the edge of the Greenland ice cap, he points out that the glacier has begun retreating rapidly in the past few years with the town experiencing some of its hottest summers. Over the roar he shouts, "We are not afraid of climate change. It's the pace of change that is worrying. But we can't take away the hope that nothing can be done."

Seated next to him is R.K. Pachauri, the chairman of the Nobel Prize winning Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, which confirmed that global warming is a real threat. He replies, "It's only when you come here you understand how rapidly the earth's climate is changing. We can't do with Band-Aids. What we need is a tectonic shift in our solutions." Friedman, who is

**ICEBERG
FACTORY:** An
iceberg from
the Illulissat
Fjord is said
to have felled
the *Titanic*

**THE TONGUE OF THE GLACIER AT ILLULISSAT DISINTEGRATED IN 2002 AND THEN
RETREATED BY 12 KM RESULTING IN A TRAFFIC JAM OF ICEBERGS IN THE BAY.**

RAJ CHENGAPPA

